

By **Vikram Singh**

The author is former Director General, Uttar Pradesh Police, and now Chancellor, Noida International University

A Battle to Win their Trust

The public safety survey reveals a nation neither wholly secure nor entirely anxious but rather existing in a curious state of in-between—a patchwork quilt of confidence and concern

If **public safety is a state of mind,** then India's mindscape is a collage of contradictions, paradoxes and flickering hopes. The first-ever Gross National Behaviour survey, conducted by the India Today Group in collaboration with How India Lives, sets out to quantify not just what we do, but how safe we feel while doing it. Of course, one might debate the sample size and methodology, but this survey has the potential to spark a national conversation on the conduct and civic sensibilities that define a truly developed nation. The survey reveals a nation neither wholly secure nor entirely anxious, but rather existing in a curious state of in-between—a patchwork quilt of confidence and concern that defies simple characterisation.

Kerala, the verdant coastal state known for its near-universal literacy and robust social indices, sits atop the public safety rankings. Yet even in this paragon of safety, contradictions emerge. While only 10 per cent of Keralites report feeling unsafe in their neighbourhoods—the lowest figure nationwide—the state demonstrates a curious anomaly: an overwhelming 96 per cent express discomfort with stray dogs in their vicinity. This aversion appears well-founded, as Kerala recorded a staggering 316,000 dog bite cases in 2024, more than doubling from 135,000 in 2017. One might say that in Kerala, the threat is not from one's fellow citizens but from their feral four-legged counterparts.

At the opposite end of the spectrum lies Uttar Pradesh, India's most populous state and the anchor of its political heartland. Here, a sobering 30 per cent respondents acknowledge unsafe areas in their neighbourhoods, while a third would not feel comfortable reporting a violent crime to the police. This reluctance to engage with law enforcement speaks to a deeper institutional mistrust, one that echoes across the nation in varying degrees.

In fact, what emerges from this mosaic of data is a nation still negotiating the fundamental contract between citizen and state. The willingness to report a crime—84 per cent nationwide—suggests a theoretical faith in institutional justice. Yet the actual reporting rates from major cities may reveal a profound implementation gap. Indians appear to believe in the idea of law enforcement more than in its practice. The legacy of an indifferent police force takes years to erase, but every unreported crime scrawls a scar on the collective conscience.

Take eve-teasing, that polite phrase for an impolite menace. While 42 per cent of all respondents acknowledge the presence of eve-teasing in their areas, the figure rises to 44 per cent when women alone are asked. This seemingly small gap exposes a telling social blind spot. It reveals how public perception can also fail to perceive the everyday indignities women endure in public spaces. Karnataka, considered among India's more progressive states given its tech-hub status, demonstrates the survey's most alarming statistic on this front: nearly four in five respondents (79 per cent) acknowledge that the state's women face harassment in public spaces.

The reluctance to engage with law enforcement speaks to a deeper institutional mistrust, one that echoes across the nation in varying degrees

Contrast that with neighbouring Tamil Nadu where only 17 per cent of